

Graphic Organizers as Cognitive Scaffolds in Grade 3 Reading: Sequencing, Cause-Effect, and Compare-Contrast

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ABSTRACT

This article examines the use of visual and spatial organizers in Increasing Reading Power 3. The source employs first-next-last structures and flowcharts for sequencing, paired cause-and-effect boxes for causal reasoning, tables for drawing conclusions, and Venn diagrams for comparing and contrasting. These formats transform verbal relationships into visible structures that learners can complete, inspect, and revise. The analysis focuses on three functions of the organizers: reducing the amount of information that must be held in working memory, making relationships among ideas visible, and creating a bridge from story comprehension to written response. The article also discusses the progression from picture-based sequencing to text-based organizers and from partly structured tasks to more independent comparison activities.

Keywords: graphic organizers, Venn diagram, sequencing, cause and effect, compare and contrast, Grade 3 reading, visual scaffold

INTRODUCTION

Young readers often understand a relationship before they can explain it in a long written response. Graphic organizers can externalize that relationship by giving the learner a visual place to put events, causes, effects, similarities, and differences. The source book repeatedly uses such structures rather than relying only on conventional multiple-choice questions.

This article analyzes the visual organizers as instructional scaffolds. It does not evaluate their effectiveness experimentally; instead, it examines how the layouts correspond to the target comprehension skills.

Sequencing: From Pictures to Flowcharts

Module 2 teaches sequencing as the order in which things happen and introduces clue words such as first, then, next, and finally. In the first activity, learners number pictures from 'The Kitten' according to what happened first, next, and last. The second activity replaces the pictures with a flowchart in which missing events must be inserted between a starting condition and a final outcome.

This progression is notable because the learner first manipulates visible scenes and then reconstructs the event sequence in words. The flowchart makes temporal order spatial: one event is placed below another, allowing the reader to see story chronology rather than hold the entire sequence mentally.

Cause and Effect: Making Directionality Visible

Module 4 defines a cause as why something happens and an effect as what happens. Its activities use explicit cause-effect wording and later a two-column flowchart

in which either a cause or an effect is missing. The visual direction from cause to effect supports the conceptual distinction between explanation and result.

This is especially useful because causal relationships can be reversed accidentally by beginning readers. A paired organizer encourages the learner to ask which statement belongs on the 'why' side and which belongs on the 'what happened' side.

Compare and Contrast: The Venn Diagram

Module 8 explicitly teaches the Venn diagram as a graphic organizer for comparing persons, places, things, animals, stories, and ideas. The first activity compares the cow and the carabao by placing similarities in the overlap and differences in the outer circles. A later activity applies the same structure to the city and the barrio, using transportation, surroundings, weather, and sounds as comparison dimensions.

The visual overlap is the central instructional feature. Similarity is not merely listed; it is placed in a shared area. Difference is represented through physical separation. The learner therefore sees the logic of comparison while generating the content.

Organizer-Skill Alignment

Target skill Organizer used in source Relationship made visible

Sequencing Events Picture numbering; vertical flowchart
Before-after order and story chronology

Cause and Effect Cause/effect paired boxes Why an event happened and what resulted

Drawing Conclusions Two-column evidence/conclusion table
Observed event and reasonable conclusion

Comparing and Contrasting Venn diagram Shared attributes and distinct attributes

Five journal-style articles derived from Serdeña (2021)

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Target skill Organizer used in source Relationship made visible

Fantasy and Reality Two-column classification table

Placement of statements into mutually exclusive categories

From Supported to Independent Use

The organizers vary in how much information is supplied. Some tasks are partly completed and provide a model answer; others leave larger spaces for the learner to generate content. This variation can serve as a scaffold if the sequence is intentional: model the structure, complete it with support, then ask the learner to use the same structure with a new text or familiar topic.

The source's 'Proofread & Write' tasks often move beyond the organizer into prose. This is an important transition. An organizer should not become the final goal; it is most useful when it helps the learner prepare an accurate oral or written explanation.

Design Considerations for Future Editions

A future version could strengthen visual consistency by using the same directional conventions across modules, adding short labels such as 'evidence,' 'conclusion,' 'similar,' and 'different,' and ensuring that the answer key mirrors the layout used by the learner. These refinements would make the organizer itself part of the comprehension strategy.

Teachers can also ask learners to explain why an answer belongs in a particular section. For example, after filling

the shared portion of a Venn diagram, a pupil can state the sentence 'Both animals...' This verbalization connects spatial organization with language production.

LIMITATIONS

The material demonstrates the presence and instructional alignment of graphic organizers, but it does not contain comparative data showing whether the visual formats improve comprehension more than text-only exercises. The conclusions here therefore concern design logic, not measured effect.

CONCLUSION

Increasing Reading Power 3 uses visual organizers in ways that match the structure of several comprehension skills. Sequencing is represented as order, cause and effect as direction, comparison as overlap and separation, and classification as placement into categories. These visual structures can serve as bridges between reading a passage and explaining the relationships within it.

REFERENCE

Serdeña, G. A. E. (2021). Increasing reading power 3. Shirley Publishing House.